



Google goes blue

Google's new favicon follows the continuing trend of the company's new adopted colour being implemented across major products.
<http://dgit.in/NChBHz>

of focusing points (cross and normal), are generally slightly bigger in size and offer some level of resilience against the weather. We would still not recommend dropping one, or gallivanting with it in the pouring rains.

We're looking at the D7000 from Nikon and the A77 from Sony here in our test and it's quite an exciting one. It's important to keep in mind that the two cameras we're comparing here come from two very different backgrounds and offer many distinct features and performance perks.

Features and Design

The Nikon D7000 is built on the long standing Nikon design that has been employed on cameras like the D300, D300s and even the D800. The Sony Alpha 77 on the other hand is a rogue entrant here, coming from an amalgamation of Sony and Konica Minolta. Nikon has always focused on squeezing every bit of performance out of their products, while Sony takes that formula and adds the glitter of "higher numbers" to it. For example, the A77 sported the world's first 24 megapixel APS-C sensor.

When looking at the two cameras straight on, the Nikon looks like a simpton, while the Alpha looks like body builder with considerably raised curves on top (leading out of the hot shoe flash and onto the edges). It is even taller than the D7000, which is probably due to the semi-transparent mirror and phase detect sensor placed where the prism should be. The Alpha is a pure phase-detect focusing machine, while the D7000 uses the traditional contrast-detect AF method. The Alpha 77 sports 19 AF points, 11 of which are cross type while the D7000 has 39 focusing points with 9 being cross type.

The Alpha 77 comes with Sony's TruBlack tilt-swivel LCD, something the film makers (and we) will just love. It permits the camera to film at angles that previously required elaborate rigs and external monitors.

In our test, the D7000 surpassed the Alpha 77 by just a few points. It's probably because the D7000 has dual SD card slots while the A77 has just one.

Build and Ergonomics

The D7000, in our opinion, looks just like a smaller D800. In fact, it doesn't look much different from the standard Nikon cameras, which have come to take on an established design formula (save for the D4). The Alpha is a new comer to the game, marking Sony's entry into the semi-pro DSLR market, and it is quite a contender.

The buttons on the Alpha 77 made us feel like not a lot of thought was given to what was placed and where. Despite spending a lot of time with the Alpha, we still had troubles accessing certain features such as changing the metering mode. It looks like the menu system on the DSLR is straight out of Sony's point and shoot cameras, something that we are not particularly fond of as it makes the menu look a little cluttered. It is, however, intuitive. The D7000 from Nikon is quite a treat to use in this regard, with clear button placement. The menu, however, it's quite a pain to traverse through. While the extent of weather sealing on the D7000 is not all that clear, Sony clearly states that the Alpha 77 is designed to withstand some light rain. The rubber seals on the ports feel sturdy and tight, the same as the Nikon so we wouldn't worry about any accidental water leakage.

Performance

The Alpha 77 is a 24-megapixel-12-fps shooting monster while the D7000 is a 16 megapixel shooter capable of 6 frames per second at best.

In our outdoors test, we found that both the cameras actually rendered colors and contrast equally well. We're guessing it has something to do with the fact that Sony's been making sensors for Nikon for quite some time, with the D7000 being no exception. Good job Sony! As for the color renditions and contrast levels, both the cameras gave a rather saturated image, along with a mild contrast. Needless to say, we shot plenty of RAW files, which we had absolutely no need to edit for color or contrast. With multi-segment metering enabled, the exposures seemed very well balanced, with an acceptable

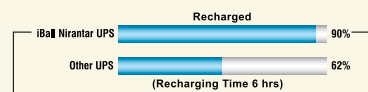


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